

Your Productized Consulting

G U I D E

by Jane Portman

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Introduction

Who is this book for?

It doesn't matter whether you're a strategic advisor or a hands-on craftsman — any kind of services can be packaged and sold online. Therefore, this book will be helpful for any professional freelancer or consultant who wants to try a better, painless way of doing client work. This includes, but is not limited to, designers, developers, marketers, and copywriters.

This guide will also help if you're looking to productize the services of your entire team. All the recommendations apply to both individuals and teams, and there's bonus section for teams at the end of the book.

What is productized consulting?

Productized consulting is a term for selling consulting services as a fixed-price, value-based offering with a pre-defined process.

It's your ultimate silver bullet in the bitter world of client work. This short, actionable guide will help you get started with productized consulting fast — maybe even craft your first offer today.

I've been working in as an independent consultant for 5 years (and 13 years in the industry in general). It's been slow and fast, high and low, but I always come back to productized consulting. There's no reason why you shouldn't do the same!

Before we get started, I want to say huge thanks to the amazing thought leaders who I learned from. I'm literally standing on the shoulders of giants: Patrick McKenzie, Amy Hoy, Brennan Dunn, Nathan Barry, Joanna Wiebe, and the smartest folks of the Productized Consulting Roundtable that I belong to.

I've gathered the knowledge below through 5 years of learning and hands-on experimentation. If someone told me all of this 5 years ago, it would've made my path to success much more straightforward.

Therefore, I'm hoping it will be helpful to you, my dear friend! Now all the tools are in your skilful hands.

Why is productized consulting so attractive for your clients?

If you've ever hired anyone, then you probably know the truth about choosing a freelancer or consultant: your clients are scared to death to hire you for the first time! There's a whole range of questions spinning around in their head:

Can I trust this person? How much will this cost me? What does the process look like? What do I even need? What if the scope spirals out of control and I waste my precious budget with the wrong person?

In this scenario, clients (including myself when hiring others) remind me of a poor student in a fancy restaurant. Yes, they know their fine food! Yes, they would love a good steak! But the steak is sold by weight, and even though

the price per pound is in the menu, you still have no idea if you have enough money in your pocket (or if you'll be paying for it months after you leave the restaurant).

Productized consulting addresses all of the frustrations above. It gathers your services into a beautiful package where everything is clearly priced, clearly labeled, and extremely attractive. Now prospective clients know exactly what they're getting and exactly how much it will cost!

What does productized consulting do for you?

Besides making you an easy hire, productized consulting helps you achieve other very important business benefits.

It eliminates proposals. A fixed-price offer serves as a perfect stepping stone for an initial engagement. Clients commit to a small project to try out your services with a specific result in mind. Later, should they need more work done, it's now a totally different ballgame! Now they trust you, and you don't need to re-sell yourself with a new proposal. Everything boils down to a simple agreement.

It allows you to set your own rules. When you sell productized consulting, you're the one in control: you show that you know what you're doing, and what's best for you and your client. You define the process from the start, set strict boundaries for your clients, and proactively protect yourself from scope creep.

It helps you transition to value-based pricing. Are you still billing by the hour? Then you might not yet understand that it's a huge trap. As your career progresses, you get punished — paid less! — when you get the job done faster. With productized consulting, on the contrary, you get rewarded for efficient work. You also have all instruments on hand to explain the value of your services in detail.

It helps you sell recurring services. Retainers solve cash-flow problems, but they get even better when sold as a value-based package, not just a number of hours per month.

Planning Your Services Lineup

Let’s think backwards

 **UI Breakfast**

[Services](#) [Products](#) [Podcast](#) [Blog](#) [Contact](#)

UI/UX Services to Help Your Software Business

For your convenience, I'm offering my best consulting services as low-risk, fixed-price packages. If you didn't find a package to meet your needs, drop me a line at jane@uibreakfast.com to discuss a custom engagement.

60-Minute Strategy Call

Want to make sure you're heading in the right direction before your build anything big? Need a quick UI/UX teardown of your product? Can't figure out the next steps? I'm here to help with this laser-focused strategy call.

This 60-minute call currently costs \$299. [Learn more](#)

Single Feature Optimization

Sometimes you only need help in one problematic area of your web application. This package was developed specifically for such situations, when we can achieve a quick win with a bit of actual design work (not just recommendations). For the best results, it comes with a complimentary 60-minute strategy call.

This package currently costs \$895. [Email me to get started](#)

Custom UI Audit

In this UI audit, I'll take a fresh professional look at your web app, determine critical design flaws, and put together an actionable plan for improving your UI/UX. You'll get a fancy (and incredibly useful) PDF report with a detailed screen-by-screen teardown of your web app.

Audit packages start at \$1,795. [Learn more](#)

The [Services](#) page above is one of the most visited pages on my website, and it’s simple as pie! I’m naming my most popular services and putting a price tag on each of them.

It may be simple, but it strikes a deep chord with prospective clients. People love — love! — seeing price information on your website. It's like a restaurant menu displayed publicly at the door. It also puts a constructive anchor inside people's minds: if your price is too high for them right now, you become an aspirational hire. They'll still have great respect for you, keeping you in mind for future projects.

SERVICES TO GROW YOUR SHOPIFY SALES

FORGET HOURLY BILLING, OUR FIXED-PRICE, FIXED-SCOPE SERVICES MEAN NO BLOWN BUDGETS

Store Setup & Design

Premium Theme Setup

\$3495

POPULAR

Have a premium theme you love but don't have the time or inclination to set it up?

Knowing how to set up a theme for optimum conversion rate is something that most store owners simply don't have experience to do.

[Learn More](#)

Concierge Onboarding

\$6495

Starting from scratch? We can help.

We'll assist you by:

- Creating your account
- Picking a theme for your brand
- Setting up your store, theme, and checkout process.
- Providing 30 days of training

[Learn More](#)

Custom Themes

\$24,995

In the last five years, we've built custom websites for Verizon, the NFL, and Hilton Hotels– and we can help you achieve your vision too. We can be your development partner, and build your custom theme using our own best practices.

[Learn More](#)

Marketing: Attract Customers & Boost Sales

Facebook Sales Funnels

\$3495

POPULAR

As a busy store owner, learning to use Facebook Ads to effectively generate sales can be a time consuming endeavor.

Instead, we can setup a sales funnel using Facebook that segments and targets customers through their relationship with your brand.

[Learn More](#)

Email Flow Automation

\$2995

Email is one of the best growth channels. Our clients typically see 10-20% additional revenue.

By sending emails automatically based on a customers behavior, you'll ensure that each customer gets the right message at the right time.

[Learn More](#)

Conversion Rate

Optimization

\$2995

NEW

Using a combination of analytics tools, we find your hottest opportunities for growth, implement, and test them on an ongoing basis.

By watching how your Visitors are really using your site, our action plan will lead you directly to the biggest opportunity.

[Learn More](#)

Here's another good example of a services page from [Ethercycle](#) (Shopify agency by Kurt Elster). They have more advanced multi-column formatting, but the structure remains the same: package name, brief description, price, and a call to action.

You could use the basic definition of productized consulting to jump right into creating your first consulting package now. But instead of haphazardly pulling something together, be more strategic and plan backwards.

First, roughly plan your entire services lineup. You'll want to provide services in each price range to accommodate various needs and budgets, but make sure you keep every engagement profitable for yourself. Grocery stores can afford to have loss leaders, but you're not a grocery store! You should never discount your time and expertise, or price anything "to get someone in the door." That will only lead to frustration, scope creep, and referrals for more of the same.

If you want to introduce a new service, your MVP (minimum viable product) is merely one paragraph of text on your services page. All you have to come up with is a name, brief description, and price. No need to write a specific sales page, design a fancy website, or go through laborious market research. Just put a name on it!

Over time, give each package (or at least some of them) a dedicated sales page of its own. The services page should serve as a table of contents that shows packages in the order of ascending value and price.

Planning your productized consulting line

The price tags below roughly reflect my client ecosystem: small-to-medium SaaS businesses based in the U.S. You might want to make adjustments if you're operating in other parts of the world or with different types of clients. As you work out your productized consulting rates and recalculate your pricing structure, always err on the side of charging more.

A strategy call (\$200–500) allows people to get your strategic insight without paying top dollar or making any serious commitments. Ideally, it acts as a stepping stone to other gigs. From my experience, it frequently attracts people with smaller budgets who couldn't afford your services otherwise. Clients with good budgets proceed straight to your next offering — entry-point gig.

An entry-point gig (\$500–2,000) is a packaged mini-version of your core service. It provides a ton of value while remaining affordable, and serves as an amazing stepping stone to larger custom gigs. Consider offering a written strategic assessment (audit, roadmap, etc), some hands-on work, or a bit of both. I recommend using tiered pricing here, including at least a basic package and a premium package.

An advanced offering (under \$5,000) is another packaged version of your core services, targeting clients with larger budgets and bigger project scopes and deliverables. Consider listing your daily or weekly rate for custom gigs, too.

A recurring monthly service (\$500–1,500) is a wonderful way to sell retainers based on value, not on hours. Three to five recurring monthly clients can provide significant income, and free you up from “fishing” for new clients every month (maybe not entirely, but significantly).

These were the most popular package types. Read on for a few more options to enhance your product line.

A tiny gig (under \$1,000) allows you to help people with a bit of hands-on work, typically less than a day. When a client asks for something small, you just say, “Oh, I have a package specifically for that, it costs \$875.” No need to do a custom estimate every time — you’d have to tie it to hours, and hourly billing is crazy ineffective.

Most likely, a tiny gig is not going to be a popular package, but it serves a strategic purpose of weeding out a special kind of tire-kicker who is trying to buy just a few hours of your time. Never allow clients to break down your work to hourly tasks!

A training offer, lined up alongside your consulting services, instantly demonstrates your credibility as an expert — even if training isn’t your primary source of income. Whatever your industry, coaching and training (both for individuals and teams) can be lucrative and lead to more gigs down the road.

A “Mercedes” offer (\$5,000–10,000 or more) serves as a price anchor for other packages, making them look more affordable. It also boosts your credibility: “Oh, they must be in high demand if they’re so confident to charge \$8,000 for something.”

This might be obvious, but make sure you only list services that you’re actually willing to do for the listed price! This can be a consulting equivalent of your dream leadership role — like a CTO for hire (for developers), a chief editor (for writers), or a creative director (for designers).

My own “Mercedes” offer goes back to a real client episode, when I was offered a leadership role. I brainstormed all pros and cons, reflected on the value I’d be bringing to the role, and came up with a number. The gig didn’t work out, but I used this situation as an inspiration for this top level offering.

Some examples for you

Here's my own services lineup (you can find the details [here](#)):

- 60-Minute Strategy Call (\$299 for 60 minutes, \$495 for 2 hours)
- Single Feature Optimization (\$895)
- Custom UI Audit (\$1,795 and \$3,495 with hands-on work — after I added the premium package, it's the only one clients want)
- Custom UI/UX Design (\$1,450/day)
- Monthly Creative Direction for Teams (starting from \$8,000/mo)

Benedikt Deicke is a good friend of mine, and also my co-founder for Userlist.io (our SaaS product). Here's what he has to offer (details [here](#)):

- 60-Minute Consultation Call (€256)
- Performance Review (€2,560)
- Ongoing Ruby on Rails Maintenance (starting at €2,048/month)
- Product Development (€1,536/day)
- Remote Technical Training for Individuals (starting at €3,072/month)
- Remote Technical Training for Teams (starting at €7,680/month)

Shaping Your Offer

Now that you have a rough idea of your productized consulting line, let's put together your first package.

Defining your audience

Nothing exists in isolation. Whether you're selling a software product, a book, or a consulting package, everything should start with an audience. Who are you serving? Who is your ideal client?

Remember, you can't be everything to everyone. In order to charge a premium rate, you have to niche down. It allows you to sharpen your skills and specialize in a particular area, which makes you a very attractive hire ("We're not the first, she knows our business ecosystem inside out!").

But how do you pick your audience? Write down your top 3 favorite clients. What do they have in common? Look for a certain business type, a certain size, a certain step in their lifecycle, a certain geographic location (or all of these criteria).

Guerrilla consultants say "niche down until it hurts" or "you can't niche down too much." The small percentage of clients with really big budgets don't want to hire generalists! They want to hire someone who is the expert on their particular problem and can deliver proven results. If you want to work with those clients, you need to be the specialist they're looking for.

Defining your expertise

One thing I see too often on websites of other designers is a sales pitch like this: “I focus on creating amazing websites, mobile applications, and illustrations.” The first thing I think to myself is, how can you focus on three completely different kinds of work? Focusing means picking just one thing and saying no to everything else.

You might’ve been a generalist — before today. But now it’s time to reflect on your professional experience and plan a path to your niche.

Your sweet spot lies in the intersection of these criteria:

1. What do you like to do the most?
2. What kind of projects do you find yourself doing more often?
3. What has the highest value for your clients?

Let’s walk through them.

What do you like to do the most? What work makes you feel excited and energized? Write down your top 3 favorite projects. What did you do for these clients? If it was a whole range of things, what part did you enjoy the most?

Let’s take designers as an example. Simply “design” is absolutely not acceptable. “UI/UX design” is better, but still leaves you with a wide range of things to do. “UI/UX for web applications” (websites, mobile apps) is much

better. But again, there's a number of stages involved: research, wireframes, visual design, front-end code. Maybe you love visual design but hate research. Focus on one or two stages and be very clear about the parts you love!

There's such a thing as "a rolodex moment." Whenever anyone says "I'm a lawyer and I need a website", any of your friends or clients should instantly exclaim, "I know John, he does exactly that." Your expertise combined with your audience defines your positioning and makes you a memorable specialist.

As you build your tagline, be careful not to overcomplicate your message. Make it practical. Make it relevant to real-life use cases. Use common language. For example, "I build membership websites for multimedia content" probably means a lot to you, especially if your whole life revolves around that. But does an average person know what these are? Instead, try something like "I help people create video courses."

I find it easier to focus on a specific medium. For a UI/UX designer or a developer it could be websites, web applications, or mobile applications. For a copywriter it could be articles, sales pages, or social media.

Here's how niching can make a freelancer's life easier. After focusing on web applications myself, I often receive inquiries about websites or mobile applications. It's never been easier to say no! I've dedicated so much time to web apps that I feel 200% competent in this area. At the same time, I haven't designed a mobile app in years. Should I decide to take up a mobile project,

I'd have to spend extra days or weeks studying the latest trends in order to provide quality service. It's obviously not sustainable. So I say "no" and not even wince, no matter how big the project is.

What do you find yourself doing over and over again? What kinds of inquiries are clients making? What kind of inquiries make you accept without hesitation? Think of common themes and processes in your work. They're obviously in high demand, and therefore, are the perfect candidates for productized consulting.

A word of warning: don't niche in something you don't like just because it's popular. It may pay off today, but over time you'll find yourself enjoying your work less and less, and you'll have to niche all over again. It's important to consider the viability of your niche — but the decision should be supported by demand, not inspired by it.

What has the highest value for your clients? To find out what you're good at, just ask your clients. Why did they hire you? What parts of the work do clients always compliment? What do they always brag about? What is it about your experience that makes you the best person for the job? These answers can help you figure out which of your services to focus on.

Sometimes it's obvious that a certain part of your work is more important to your client, while the rest can be delegated to an assistant or another professional. Such approach can save your client money and free you up from undesirable routine work.

Maybe you're brilliant at conceptualizing new products, while other routine things can be delegated to a junior designer. Maybe you're brilliant at writing articles, while stuffing the company's social media accounts should be done by someone else.

Or sometimes it's a different situation: you might enjoy organizing things, while the client would be thrilled to get it off their plate. So you could help them handle the minutiae of their daily business, plan and log activities, hire and manage subcontractors, etc.

There are two ways to approach this: *"done for you because you're busy"* (convenience), and *"done for you because you don't have the skills"* (expertise). You can do both to make your client happy, but keep in mind that expertise is always valued higher than convenience.

Three levels of involvement

For each of your productized consulting packages, you can offer different levels of involvement: strategic guidance, review & report, and hands-on work.

Strategic guidance, where you briefly review something and give verbal recommendations. In practice, this translates to strategy calls, mentoring, coaching, and other kinds of advice. These packages have the best value per dollar, because the client receives key expert insights without engaging in an expensive gig.

To make this kind of package feel more substantial, you can offer the following perks to surprise and delight your client:

- a recording of the call;
- a brief email recap with the key points (it usually takes very little time to write immediately after the call);
- free email follow-up after the call for a certain period of time, e.g. 7 days (most likely, people won't take you up on this at all, but it relieves the fear of being charged for additional questions).

Review & report, where you take extra time to review the product (or project) and provide written recommendations. In practice, this translates to audit reports, roadmaps, plans, etc. Clients love to see what they're doing right and wrong in their existing products, so your reports have a great chance of becoming a best-selling package. This costs more money than verbal advice, but still not as much as detailed hands-on work.

Hands-on work, where you're getting your hands dirty and actually building something for your client. In practice, this translates to developing software, designing, writing copy, etc.

As you grow as a professional, you'll find yourself gravitating towards strategic guidance rather than hands-on work. However, there are some situations where hands-on work trumps any advice. I also find such work necessary for "stretching professional muscles" over time so your skills don't grow stale. It's also important to keep adding new work to your portfolio, so that you always have a recent example of your work in action.

Defining the price

Putting a fixed price tag on your service is the most important (and magical) part of productized consulting. It means security for your client, and profit for you — or at least, it should! Read on to find out how to price your offerings correctly.

Think of your delivery time and double it. How long will it take you to ship this? Think of this time, double it, and multiply that by your internal hourly rate. This will account for any potential overhead — both administrative (exchanging emails, arranging the call, etc) and work-related (revisions or scope creep), and prevent you from losing time or money.

I'll show you how to protect yourself from possible scope creep in the next few chapters, but surprising and delighting the client is a different story. It's your ultimate goal! You want to account for extra polish and high-end touches from the beginning, so increase your price accordingly.

Create pricing tiers (packages). Pricing tiers or packages give clients the opportunity to pay you more if they feel their budget or project warrants it. The higher priced tiers also make the basic tiers look less expensive. Offering options subtly directs clients to a choice of “Which package should I purchase?” instead of making them wonder “Should I purchase this or not?”

One classic model, specifically popular in self-published books and SaaS, includes three tiers: 1x, 2.2x, and 5x. These numbers were disclosed by Gumroad's Ryan Delk at MicroConf 2014, and have been the gold standard ever since.

The other model, [suggested by Sean D'Souza](#), only has two tiers: the plain thing (1x) and the same exact thing with a bonus (1.15x). This makes the second package a no-brainer for your customer and simplifies their decision-making process.

Charge more! This simple mantra has multiple benefits. When you're hiring someone on Fiverr or Upwork, the low cost of the work leaves you expecting an ugly surprise any second. When you're hiring someone for a few thousand dollars, those feelings disappear and leave you confident and excited about what's to come. It's true:

- Clients feel proud of hiring an expensive professional.
- Clients feel secure when they hire an expensive professional.
- Clients listen to you much more carefully when they pay you high rates.
- High rates account for possible overhead.
- You feel proud of being well rewarded for your work. Naturally, you do a better job, present your work more confidently, and create a stronger client relationship.

Pretty magical, right?

Recurring services

Recurring services are a special breed of productized consulting. In a classic retainer model, you're selling chunks of your time in pre-paid blocks (e.g. 10 hours of work per month). With productized consulting, you're using the same essential model, but taking the focus off of hours and adding in all the benefits, such as value-based pricing.

To put together a recurring service package, follow all the advice from the previous sections, plus consider a few more things:

Automate your billing. Stop chasing invoices every month and embrace the magic of automated billing. Set up recurring billing in Stripe, PayPal, or another invoicing solution. Extra bonus: if the client doesn't show up, you can still bill them for this month (just make sure that scenario is described in your contract). Alternatively, you can suggest a 50% refund for a no-show month.

Assign a get-together date. Make it easier for your work to get done every month! Instead of chasing your client, determine a date when you'll start working on your own, or set up a recurring monthly call.

Limit the contract. Your recurring service is not friendship or marriage — it doesn't have to last forever! Make the potential ending comfortable for both parties. Agree on a specific date, like 6 months, when you'll get together and think whether extending the contract is viable or not. Include notice terms of 30 or 60 days so there are no surprises.

Set a goal and make a roadmap. Establish a good way to track the outcome! Set a specific goal — a metric or a scope of work — and work towards it. Delight your client in the first month by shipping a complimentary roadmap (wrapped in a fancy PDF) — you'll set clear expectations and prove the value of your work.

Don't book yourself solid. Recurring revenue is reliable and extremely tempting. But don't book over 50% of your capacity with recurring engagements! Life happens, and opportunities can't be scheduled — you have to account for new exciting clients, personal projects, conferences, vacations, and other unpredictable things.

I learned this lesson the hard way: in the spring of 2015 I booked myself heavily with monthly creative direction for several software companies, and then couldn't say no to an awesome new project. Then a book deal from InVision came along, and I couldn't say no to them, either. This resulted in a heavy burnout and a complete 6-month break from client work!

Think of vacations. If you prefer longer breaks which can't be tucked in between monthly sessions, then discuss it separately. Reserve the right to skip a month once or twice a year, and describe the procedure.

Consider a larger pre-payment. An advance payment for the first month is, of course, mandatory. But sometimes the first month requires a lot of work, so you'd want to mitigate the risk. For example, you can bill 3 months ahead

to justify the onboarding costs and to make sure the client is serious about your engagement. You can even go as far as the cost of the entire contract length.

Writing Your Sales Page

When you build your business on a productized consulting model, the “minimum viable” version of your offer is merely a paragraph on your Services page. The full version of your offer, however, is a long-form sales page on your website. Alternatively, it can be a PDF document, or a live document in Google Docs or Dropbox Paper (these formats look less impressive by default, though).

If you’re putting up your sales page on your website, then pick a simple, memorable URL slug because you’ll find yourself typing it very often. For example, *yourdomain.com/call* works great for a strategy call.

Even though I am a designer, I strongly believe that content is more important than design — especially in this case. So please don’t fret about fancy details; just pick a WordPress theme with clear typography and get started. The important thing is to capture everything in writing — both your sales pitch and your “terms and conditions.” Such page serves as a proposal (and often as a contract) — for multiple clients at once, so it’s worth the time investment to write it properly!

Finally, keep in mind that your sales page is not a legally binding document, so you’ll need to sign an actual contract with the client down the road (or at least provide a formal invoice). Make sure that the contract terms match the details from your sales page.

How to write

Don't beat around the bush with vague business words: always choose the most clear and concise way to say something. Don't get too wordy. Some online celebrities are well-known for humongous sales pages. Indeed, nothing is too much for an interested client. But realistically, does it need to be 10,000 words long?

Use plain English and be very straightforward with your words. Clarify, if necessary. Educate in a friendly way, without being patronizing. After all, your goal is not to lure the client in with vague promises! Your goal is to provide as much information about your service as possible, and make your client fall in love with it — but *only* if they're a good fit.

Whenever possible, position your copy from a business standpoint; show how useful the results of your work will be down the road. Put a value-based spin on your language.

And the last, but not least — make sure you sound like yourself! Your sales copy, your blog posts, your emails, and your ultimate deliverables should feel like they belong to the same author — not a haphazard set of writers and marketers.

In the end of this book you'll find a few resources specifically on writing long-form sales copy, while this chapter will focus on what exactly you should include from the business standpoint.

Following the structure

The classic structure of a long-form sales page can be described as “pain, dream, fix.” I prefer a longer formula — “pain, dream, fix, objections, call to action.” There’s a ton you can read on this topic, including my favorite book *[The Brain Audit](#)* by Sean D’Souza. Here’s a brief overview of my longer formula so that you can get things rolling right away.

First, make your reader freeze in their tracks by identifying a specific pain they’re experiencing right now. Then, describe “a dream” — how awesome their life can be if this problem was resolved. And only then is it time to introduce “a fix” by describing your service.

In the “objections” section predict (and overcome) common client objections, which makes them feel like you’re reading their mind. And finally, provide a good call to action, so that the reader can take their first step right away.

Now let’s take a closer look at each of these five sections.

Naming a pain specific to your audience

Your clients are bombarded with ads and sales messages every day, all day. Over time, they become nearly blind to promotional copy. However, there’s one thing that still catches their attention every single time: accurately and profoundly naming a specific problem that they’re struggling with. And that’s what you should do in your primary headline!

Since you've already settled on a specific audience, naming their problem in a specific way shouldn't be difficult. Knowing who exactly you're talking to will make your language “crispy” and effective. This is one more benefit of niching so deeply — you know your audience and can speak to them with great insight.

I remember writing sales copy for my first book, *Mastering App Presentation*, in 2013. I was very excited about the topic and thought that it would be useful both for designers who are presenting their UI/UX work and for product owners who are selling their apps. So instead of writing for one audience in simple, straightforward language, I spent a lot of time trying to make the copy vague enough to fit both use cases! It took enormous energy, and needless to say, the result was totally blunt and ineffective.

What's surprising is that niching to one audience doesn't cut you off from others. Magically, when you write for a small niche audience really well, prospective clients outside this audience only see your brilliant skills — not your niche. They end up thinking, “Oh maybe she can do the same, but for us...”

Describing the dream

After naming the pain, get the client excited about your upcoming solution by painting a picture of “the dream.”

What would life look like if their pain dissolved? What value and benefits would they receive? How would their business improve? How awesome would they feel? How great would they look in front of others?

Describing your fix well

Next, tell your potential client what exactly you do and why. You aren't just writing sales copy. You're designing — and describing! — your work process for each new client down the road.

In each gig, there are three phases to think about: discovery, execution, and delivery. Don't just describe your own process — describe how you're going to interact with your client at each stage and what they'll need to do to keep up their side of the bargain.

Discovery. How are you going to collect information before getting your hands dirty? Will you do a client call, a questionnaire, any kind of research? What does the client need to supply? When is the payment due?

Sidenote: you should always get started only after receiving a 100% advance payment. Make it a religious practice and never chase an invoice again in your lifetime.

Execution. How exactly are you going to do your work? What software will you use? Is there any quantifiable measure to your work — number of screens, lines of code? Will you allow for revisions? If so, how many, and how will they be handled?

Delivery. What exactly are you going to ship? A report, a video, a presentation, some work files? Will there be a closing consultation call? Are you going to provide video recording of the calls? Are you going to include a follow-up period, when the client can ask clarifying questions via email? What happens if they reach out after that follow-up period? Your clients will want to hear the details.

Protecting yourself

While productized consulting can benefit your business in profound ways, traditional consulting problems — like scope creep and schedule delays — can slip into the process if you don't plan for them in advance. Here's how to protect yourself:

Say what you won't do. Managing expectations is incredibly important when you productize your consulting services. Sometimes clients assume that your expertise includes something else, and if you do not clarify it, it can create tension in your relationship. It's your responsibility to set the boundaries

from the start: clearly state what you won't do, what's not included, and what problems you can't fix. Write it as a friendly tip — things your client should do before and after your engagement.

For example, if you do UI/UX design, you will provide wireframes or high-fidelity screen layouts in Sketch, but you won't export the assets or do any front-end coding.

Or, if you do A/B testing and conversion rate optimization, then you'll help your client improve their conversion, but you won't help them bring more traffic to sales page.

To surprise and delight your clients, connect them with a referral for those tasks, or offer a list of highly recommended colleagues. That way, you're still helping them solve their problem, you just don't have to be the one who solves it.

Describe common pitfalls. Sometimes a project fails because of some external factor, or because of a client's mistake. In fact, the more you work in the same niche, the more you'll see these common problems come up. Warn the client in advance that these problems might arise, and politely explain that it won't be your responsibility.

Does that sound like a dry and hostile disclaimer? It shouldn't be! Make it a friendly, helpful piece of information that demonstrates your experience in the field. Clients will see that avoiding common pitfalls is just one of the many benefits of working with an experienced, specialized consultant.

For example, if you provide A/B testing services, you should make it clear to your clients that a small amount of traffic can make your tests not representative. You'll be more professional — and more desirable — if you're honest and let them know that your services will yield better results if purchased later, after they drive more traffic.

Reserve the right to determine the scope. People ask me all the time, “But Jane, how do we deal with feature creep in productized consulting?” My secret is simple: I always reserve the ultimate right to determine the scope.

For example, in my [custom UI audits](#) I deal with various web applications. They vary dramatically in size and complexity. Yet I charge the same price, because I get to pick what exactly to review. Here's a fragment of my sales page with the exact wording:

“Will you review all screens in my web app? — As you know, web apps come in all shapes and sizes. I'm not familiar with yours yet, so I can't say. If you have a huge number of screens, I won't cover all of them, just 5–7 key screens that provide the most important user experience. But what are these key screens? I determine that myself, but usually it's rather obvious where we should focus. Just following common sense here!”

It's totally fine to address common sense, as long as you retain the control of the situation. After all, that's exactly what they're expecting you to do as an expert!

Overcoming objections

As your client is reading through your offerings, they will inevitably come up with questions, doubts, and objections. That's not a bad thing! It's actually your opportunity to impress them by “reading their mind” and addressing those objections before they're voiced.

Answer typical client questions. “Frequently asked questions” is a great format to address specific objections. Address issues that didn't find home in the main body of your text.

Include testimonials. Social proof is extremely important! But when you launch a new offering, you may not have specific feedback yet. Don't worry about it — just include regular testimonials from previous clients praising your expertise in general. You can replace them with specific testimonials later, as you get feedback on this offering.

Not sure how to incorporate social proof? Keep the testimonials concise. Include photos of the real people. Make sure they praise both the format and the value received. Give each testimonial a short title: pick the most exciting phrase and shorten it, like tabloids do. (Just less scandalous than tabloids!)

Provide a money-back guarantee. The famous “100% money-back guarantee” is a must-have. Don't be afraid to offer it. After all, if the gig went terribly wrong, wouldn't you give money back anyways? Not only does this remove the client's risk of moving forward with you, but it reinforces your image as an established professional.

Sidenote: for recurring engagements, specify that you will only refund the latest payment (to protect yourself from enormous refund amounts).

Invent creative guarantees. Don't stop with a generic guarantee — get more creative! Address a specific risk that worries your client the most, or highlight a single amazing feature in your service (it should preferably come with a number). One famous example belongs to Domino's Pizza: *"If it's not delivered in 30 minutes or less, it's free."* Other examples include extreme lifetime warranties, returns, or free replacements — whatever it can mean for your industry.

Don't be afraid to be brave and creative! It's highly unlikely that clients will take advantage of you (because common sense always wins), but it will make you memorable and captivating.

Listing your price

Listing the actual price of your productized consulting package is an art in itself. The key here is to not drop the number alone, but to frame it with positive information about value, timeframe, guarantees, etc. Without positive framing, your prospective client will be left to react to the price without any context of what they're getting.

Use price tiers. As discussed in the pricing section, introduce different price tiers. Guide the client to brainstorming which option to pick rather than wondering whether to hire you or not. It puts less pressure on the decision by giving an option of *“This one, this one, or this one?”* instead of *“Yes or no.”*

Create some urgency. If you’re promoting a new service with a discount, include the deadline when the discount will expire. But even if there isn’t a discount, it’s still a good idea to say that the package “currently costs” a certain amount. This creates a subtle urgency and hints that the price might rise in future.

Don’t anchor your price to your rates. Productized consulting is your entry ticket to the world of value-based pricing! Don’t ruin it by quoting your regular rates on this page, or providing information about specific hours or days required to do this job.

To get an idea, read an excerpt from my sales page for the custom UI audit. I’m introducing tiers, and surrounding the price tag with a money-back guarantee and some details about the process:

“The Basic Package currently costs \$1,395. You’ll receive an actionable audit report described above (15-20 pages).

The Premium Package costs \$2,995 and includes actual design work (redesign of a few key screens). This is what most clients request after conducting their audits. Not sure about this yet? You’re welcome to upgrade any time.

If you order right now, you'll get your audit report within 2 weeks of our initial consultation. That's way faster and more effective than waiting for a high-touch consulting opportunity.

The previous audits have collected amazing feedback. That's why I provide a full 100% money-back guarantee on this offering. If you're not happy with the audit results — I'll give you a full refund, no questions asked."

Alternatively, you can use a pricing grid similar to those found in software offers — just make sure you keep things simple, especially when you're starting out.

Creating an obvious call-to action

A landing page is only as good as its conversion rate. It should leave the reader knowing exactly what to do! And that's the job of your call-to-action (CTA) — a large button at the end of the landing page that indicates the next step. Here are a few CTAs for you, feel free to mix-and-match:

“Make a payment here.” This works best for smaller one-off engagements priced in the range of \$200–300, like strategy calls. It helps to weed out tire-kickers, which is great. However, this CTA isn't always effective: it can repel some cautious clients who'd rather talk to you first.

“Click here to schedule a call.” This is one of my favorite options, especially for calls. By scheduling a call, your client understands your availability (which is a common concern) and makes a commitment right up front. They won’t be charged until you confirm the call and send them a payment link.

“Email me at (this address).” This is a good option because it’s open-ended, and gives the client flexibility to compose a free-form letter. Giving your email address is much better than a contact form which are perceived as unreliable.

“Fill in a form/questionnaire.” Link to a detailed form with project details. This way your client can submit a structured request instead of a free-form story. You can ask hard questions before you even talk to a client — about their budget, scope of work, past projects, and more. Also, the ability to fill in a questionnaire accurately is a great indicator of your client’s personality and working style. However, there’s a drawback: forms are limiting and aren’t great if the client just wants to ask a couple free-form questions.

No matter what CTA you pick, make sure it provides detailed and friendly directions for what to do next. It’s unfortunate that a lack of understanding about the next steps is such a common barrier to new clients. It’s so easy to overcome!

Capturing leads with a freebie

Not everyone who’s reading your sales page is qualified or ready to purchase. It would be a shame to let them go without capturing their interest.

To address these prospective clients, include a “fallback” sign-up form. It can be as easy as “join my email list” — not effective, but better than nothing. However, you’ll get way more sign-ups by offering a relevant, high-value freebie. You can help the reader self-diagnose their current situation, or provide a way for them to solve the problem on their own.

Your fallback call-to-action could sound like this: *“Not ready for an expensive XXX yet? Try solving the problem yourself by using my free cheatsheet.”*

Keep in mind that consuming your freebie shouldn’t be a huge chore. A concise email course (or a cheatsheet) requires less work than a free book, and is less likely to end up in the downloads graveyard.

Sidenote: there was a frenzy of email courses going out a few years ago, and as a result readers got tired of seeing them all over the place (and receiving them). As of today, I would recommend a cheatsheet or a tiny guide as the best lead magnet.

Editing your headline and subhead

Yes, you read it correctly! When you’re done writing the page, it’s time to revisit your primary headline and subhead. As the first lines your prospective client reads, these two bits of copy are the most important things on your page and therefore deserve extra time and consideration.

Having written a number of sales pages for myself and other consultants, I've developed a formula for headlines and subheads. Here it is:

Your primary headline should call out the client's pain in a few simple, powerful words. Your goal here is to make them stop and read the subhead because they feel like you've identified their exact situation.

Your subhead should include the following:

- clear description of your audience;
- the name of your service;
- the format of your service.

As a result, your prospective client will learn what exactly you're pitching on this page. This honest approach helps the right people quickly identify with your offer — and stops the wrong people from reading too much if it's entirely irrelevant.

Getting help with your draft

It's tempting to think you can do everything yourself. But while you are perfectly capable of putting together a strong first draft of your landing page, you're not perfectly capable of editing your own work. You simply don't have the distance from your product, your client, or your landing page, and you are 100% guaranteed to miss something or make a mistake if you try to write it alone.

So, once you think you're done with your landing page, send your draft to a couple friends or colleagues for review. They can help you eliminate confusing points in your copy, add things you left out, and provide other valuable insights that will make your offer better.

For the best results, hire a professional editor. They'll proofread it and help you refine the language and structure. There are a lot of professional editors out there who charge very reasonable rates for their services. (More than other industries, every writer and editor needs a "Charge more!" banner over their desk.)

Delivering & Polishing Your Offer

You did it! You've roadmapped, brainstormed, written, and edited your way into productized consulting. But it doesn't count until you get your first client, and then another one, and another one. Here's my go-to to-do list for delivering and polishing your finished offer.

Letting people know about your offer

Let's face the truth: unless you're an enormous corporation investing heavily in SEO or ads, it's extremely unlikely that the perfect prospective client will discover your new sales page with a Google search. It's your job to get some eyeballs to your new service, and here's how you can do it:

Put it front-and-center on your website. Your new offer should be easy (and inescapable) to discover! Include the link in the first-level navigation menu, home page, services list, and your contact page.

Tell everyone you know. This is what social media was made for! Tweet, tell your friends, email your past clients. Write a blog post and email your list. Everyone should know that you have an awesome new service.

Point new clients to the service. When new prospects reach out to you for work, tell them you typically start with one of your entry-point packages (a strategy call, a roadmap, or an audit). Mention that your consulting packages provide much greater value than similar work billed hourly or daily.

Of course, new clients aren't the only ones who should hear about your new services. While your entry-level gigs will most likely be popular with new clients, your existing clients might enjoy a recurring service or a follow-up consultation call a few months after your initial engagement.

Marketing basics

Productized consulting isn't a silver bullet for all marketing problems. It does make you an easy hire by improving conversions when people are already on your website. But it doesn't solve top level marketing issues like low traffic or unclear messaging.

That said, there is one enormous benefit that productized consulting brings to your marketing: it's much easier to promote a signature service than generic "consulting." When you talk about your work, a consulting package with a catchy name will be easier to remember — which means there's a better chance that people will keep you in mind for future gigs.

Looking for more traffic? Try out all the classic marketing methods and see what works for you: writing quality guest posts, speaking at conferences, appearing at podcasts, or publishing loads of great content on your own platform. All of this should result in slow cumulative growth (no magic or unicorns). Once you have a steady flow of organic traffic because of existing content or links, you can consider ramping up your SEO efforts — but probably not before.

Effective marketing is a puzzle, and everyone's pieces will be different. But the important thing is that the opportunities are endless, and it's highly unlikely that one single thing will move the needle on its own.

Don't forget about the amazing power of referrals. There's a number of prosperous consultants who don't do any "publicity" — instead, one client refers them to another, and they keep getting new work. If you have a strong network in place and a track record for doing excellent work, consider asking for referrals as one of your key marketing methods.

Doing a test run (or two)

You don't know what you don't know until you do a test run. In fact, your first few runs will teach you many surprising things! Here's how to get the maximum value out of your test runs:

Offer your new gig at 50% off. Such a discount is irresistible! You'll get enthusiastic clients who are excited about the great deal and also forgiving to potential hiccups in the process. Be careful to limit the number of available slots, so you aren't completely booked out at half price. It will also stimulate sales by creating a sense of urgency.

Practice your process. There's no better way to refine your process than by doing it over and over again. As you do so, brainstorm potential areas for optimization. Can you set up a template project? Can you add reusable

sections to your reports? Can you think of any rules or formats to simplify the client interactions? Any other ways to reduce the organizational overhead to minimum?

Get a shiny new testimonial. Now that you've done a couple runs at a discount, it's time to replace general testimonials with those specific to this service. My favorite method is to send my clients a few questions about the value I brought to the table, and then to hand-pick the most powerful sentences to include on my services landing page. In your testimonials, try to address both for the value and the format of the engagement.

Refine your sales page. Once you've seen real clients, heard real questions, and faced real problems, it's time to revisit your sales page. Can you add more ways to protect yourself? Can you add a typical question to the FAQ section? Do you want to get more descriptive about the process? Read through your sales page again and improve it.

Avoiding common mistakes

Productized consulting requires discipline. You've confined your services into specific boundaries that allow you to ship work more efficiently at an attractive fixed price. As a side effect, you have to be strict (and confident) about your client requests.

Here are some painful mistakes I've made that I want to help you avoid:

Don't compromise on the audience, scope, or price. Your service, your rules — don't break them! Deviations can cause organizational overhead, bitter feelings, scope creep, and also prevent you from optimizing your process. Because how can you optimize something that's not consistent?

You've picked a niche (and a format) for a reason, so stick with it, because continuous repetition means improvement. If you find courage to be persistent the first few times, it will become second nature to you and get easier over time.

For example, if you work with web applications, don't try to apply the same package for a regular website — even if it's within your expertise. Put together another offering — or better yet, refer it out to someone who specializes in websites.

Don't deviate from the process. Again, stability is your key to optimization and low overhead!

If you decided to take a 100% advance payment (which I recommend you always do), don't make an exception. You'll find yourself chasing invoices later. If you require copy upfront for website design, don't make an exception. You'll find yourself designing with too many unknowns later.

It may feel like the client is putting you in these unfortunate situations, but the truth is that it's your responsibility. It's up to you to set strict boundaries and enforce them with your clients.

Exceeding expectations

Being strict with your boundaries doesn't mean you have to be completely heartless. Your ultimate goal is to delight the client with your expertise and the quality of your work. Therefore, you can (and should) invest extra effort to surprise clients and exceed their expectations on your terms.

For example, in UI/UX design an extra hour of work can make a huge difference — you can think through edge cases, design attractive blank states, organize the layers, and put together a complimentary style guide. No matter what your industry, your output should delight other professionals who'll work with it down the road.

But if the project has already gone out of scope and that extra hour will make or break your profitability, you won't feel like being generous. Accounting for extra “delight” time in your pricing means you'll be eager to spend extra time polishing your work.

Finally, multiply the perceived value of your services by presenting your work attractively. Wrap up your reports into gorgeous PDF documents. Hire a freelancer to design a template for you, or use a service like [Remarq](#) to convert your Markdown notes into a PDF report. Everything you do — even invoices — should spell professionalism and care.

Tips for teams

Depending on the context, the term “productization” sometimes refers to the services performed by an agency, not just a solo consultant. If that’s the case for you, here are my team-specific recommendations.

Keep your services line short. Better yet, focus on one signature service with a few price tiers. This way everything in your agency will revolve around a single format and you’ll benefit from streamlining the operations.

Documentation is your key to scalability. Hiring and training new team members is never easy. Strict procedures and accurate documentation will ensure that new people can get on board faster if the demand for your service suddenly grows. However, keep in mind that complexity grows exponentially with the team size — so productized services will never be truly scalable like infoproducts or SaaS.

Get brutal with your boundaries. Everyone should be strict about boundaries, but in most cases solo consultants can survive a mistake or two caused by being unreasonably generous. When you’re employing a whole team, that kind of generosity will get you in trouble fast — by causing enormous organizational overhead and cutting into your profit.

Closing Word

Dear friend,

Thank you for making the time to finish this book! I tried my best to keep it short and sweet, and hope it helps you supercharge your client work. If you haven't tried productized consulting for yourself yet, do it now. While you're still excited about the idea, sit down and start planning your services.

If you enjoyed reading this book, welcome to join 8,000 other professionals on [my email list](#) where I send out articles about UI/UX design, SaaS business, and consulting.

Want more? Here are a few other things to check out:

- UI Breakfast Podcast (shownotes are sent out to my list as well):
uibreakfast.com/podcast
- My latest SaaS product, co-founded with Claire Suellentrop and Benedikt Deicke: userlist.io
- The UI Audit, a book about web application design:
uibreakfast.com/audit

And of course, drop me a line at jane@uibreakfast.com anytime. I'd be thrilled to hear if this book helped you succeed. Thanks again, and I hope we stay in touch!

Regards,

Jane.

Resources

Service examples

- [Custom UI Audit](#) by Jane Portman
- [Draft Revise](#) by Nick Disabato
- [Week of the Website](#) by Kelsey Kreiling and Mallory Ulaszek
- [Re-Calibrate](#) by Nathan Powell
- [Snap](#) by James Turner and Lianna Patch
- [Audience Ops](#) by Brian Casel
- [Podcast Motor](#) by Craig Hewitt
- [100 Examples of Productized Services in 2017](#) — a great listing post

Pricing

- [5 Psychological Studies on Pricing That You Absolutely MUST Read](#) by Gregory Ciotti via Kissmetrics
- [Are You Making the Most Common Pricing Mistake?](#) by Nathan Barry via Fizzle
- [Pricing Psychology: 10 Timeless Strategies to Increase Sales](#) by Gregory Ciotti via HelpScout

Writing sales copy

- [Dissecting Great Sales Copy For Productized Consulting](#) by Patrick McKenzie
- [The Brain Audit](#) by Sean d'Souza (book)
- [Copy Hackers](#) by Joanna Wiebe & Lance Jones (articles and books)

Your Productized Consulting Guide

Author Jane Portman

Editor Sarah Greesonbach

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